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Designing robust electronic surveys in marketing research

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ABSTRACT

While electronic surveys are popular methods among marketing researchers, limited work surrounds how they can be effectively developed. Consequently, this article provides editorial guidance on designing robust electronic surveys to help marketing academics and graduate students to overcome notable pitfalls. Several best practices are outlined, commencing with initial issues, like formatting and interactivity. Then, some factors linked to measures and robustness checks are evaluated, including capturing instruments to test for common method variance and endogeneity bias, plus accounting for reliability and validity. Afterwards, key methodological benefits of pre-testing, conducting field interviews, pre-registration activities, and underpinning electronic surveys with appropriate theoretical lenses are discussed. Next, the paper features some final considerations, such as selecting suitable empirical contexts and respondents, adhering to ethical procedures, and managing expenses. This article ends with various summary points, alongside a checklist to minimize poor-quality survey data being collected and analyzed, facilitating advancements to marketing theory and practice.

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Introduction

Electronic surveys are popular methods within the marketing field (and in other disciplines), as they can capture information about consumers and companies used to advance theory and practice[1] (Deutskens et al., 2006; Stocchi et al., 2024). Indeed, survey-based findings have shaped pivotal issues about marketing constructs, such as a market orientation, coopetition, export performance, and consumer judgements (Cadogan et al., 2009; Crick, Friske, et al., 2024; Davis et al., 2023; Kohli et al., 1993). While electronic surveys continue to be employed by marketing scholars, there is some evidence to signify that greater clarity is needed on how they can be utilized more effectively to make stronger contributions to the extant literature. That is, it appears not all marketing researchers are well-versed in the ways electronic surveys can be effectively designed (as noted by Crick, 2024; Paas & Morren, 2018). Likewise, certain textbooks are somewhat dated (Dillman et al., 2009; Weisberg et al., 1996), for which owing to rapid methodological developments

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in survey-based research designs, contemporary insights are needed to denote best practices (Hulland et al., 2018). Thus, there is scope to outline how such tools can be improved, so that marketing academics and graduate students can overcome certain pitfalls when publishing their work in reputable journals (following Millar & Dillman, 2011).

Accordingly, from an editorial perspective, the objective of this article is to outline actionable recommendations concerning how marketing researchers (and peers in other domains) can design robust electronic surveys. By achieving this objective, three novel contributions are offered to shape the existing body of knowledge. First, via best practices, guidance is provided on how to develop stringent electronic surveys to advance marketing theory and practice (building upon Hulland et al., 2018; Stocchi et al., 2024). Second, in an era where other quantitative methods (e.g. experiments) are becoming more popular within the marketing discipline (Hamilton, 2024), the merits of electronic surveys are revisited – with stronger insights about utilizing them to yield informative findings. Third, future debates about electronic surveys, coupled with associated methodological issues (e.g. regarding common method variance and endogeneity bias), are anticipated to be generated by highlighting ways that marketing researchers can effectively use these tools (extending Antonakis et al., 2010; Zaefarian et al., 2017). Collectively, this paper is intended to be employed as a reference point for marketing academics and graduate students when designing electronic surveys to minimize poor-quality data being collected and analyzed. In doing so, a checklist is developed that outlines the salient issues pertaining to designing robust electronic surveys in the marketing discipline (and beyond).

Retrieving the pertinent literature

While this paper is not a systematic literature review, certain tools were employed to retrieve the pertinent material (building upon Donthu et al., 2022). Here, a combination of seminal and recent marketing studies (in reputable journals, using the ABDC List, not least of which the *Journal of Strategic Marketing*) were examined – focusing on methodological investigations and/or those that have employed robust electronic surveys (consistent with Crick, 2024). Additionally, the authors compared such studies from different time periods (e.g. 1980 to 2000 versus 2004 to 2024) to better-understand the evolution of the extant literature over time. In doing so, seminal work could be evaluated, as well as more recent investigations, to demonstrate currency with the existing body of knowledge. Likewise, the pivotal paper by Hulland et al. (2018) on survey-based methodologies within the marketing field was utilized as a reference point to identify key articles, as well as notable scholars in this area.

Further, textbooks were examined concerning survey-based methodologies (e.g. electronic tools) to explore other factors that are less common in journal articles (Dillman et al., 2009; Weisberg et al., 1996). Editorial experience (regarding the themes of this paper) was also utilized about issues that have been encountered when handling and refereeing manuscripts involving electronic surveys. Such factors (i.e. weak practices) are often not apparent within certain published work but are sometimes employed by less experienced marketing academics and graduate students – leading to rejection decisions. Hence, by unpacking these points,

marketing researchers can strive to design robust electronic surveys that advance theory and practice. In aggregate terms, these literature retrieval processes assisted the authors to produce an editorial guide about designing robust electronic surveys in marketing research (similar to Crick, 2024; Hulland et al., 2018). Accordingly, the subsequent discussion points are aligned with these literature retrieval techniques.

Initial considerations

Compulsory versus optional questions

Electronic surveys often have mechanisms to make questions compulsory or optional (Albaum et al., 2010). By making questions mandatory, there will be no missing data, but there might be valid reasons why respondents would prefer not to answer certain questions, such as making them feel uncomfortable and/or them genuinely not knowing the answer(s). This may lead to high attrition rates, so one route is to make some questions optional, but others are compulsory (Popovich, 2024). This way, respondents do not have to answer every question and the magnitude of missing data is reduced (albeit robust arguments on how missing data was accounted for must be articulated).

Having a clear and concise cover letter

Cover letters serve as useful introductions for electronic surveys, as they provide respondents with information about the topics being investigated, key details about data storage, and beyond (Gendall, 2005). If cover letters are too detailed (which may be impacted by an institution's ethical procedures – discussed in due course), key informants may decide to not proceed, reducing response rates and sample sizes (Park & Tsuchiya, 2021). Thus, survey researchers are advised to include a cover letter, but should keep such information as brief as possible. Here, key website links (e.g. about ethical factors – as covered later) could be used to not overload participants with such upfront information.

Interactivity in electronic surveys

There are ways to make electronic surveys interactive, like presenting questions in different styles (i.e. response formats), using various color schemes, and embedding videos (Crick et al., 2022; Davis et al., 2023). That said, there is a risk that marketing researchers become *carried away* when making their electronic surveys interactive due to being pre-occupied with style over substance. As an illustration, some electronic survey organizations offer a drag and drop function for survey questions, whereby, respondents choose answers by clicking their screens or using their finger via a smartphone. Yet, pre-testing (as discussed later) can highlight that this format is confusing[2] (see Crick, 2018). In essence, interactivity is important, but there could be a diminishing-returns effect at play (if style outweighs substance).

The length of electronic surveys

Typically, the longer that electronic surveys become, attrition rates increase (Deutskens et al., 2004). There is no rule, but one recommendation is for electronic surveys to take respondents a maximum of 10 minutes to complete (Revilla & Ochoa, 2017). This timescale assumes that relevant data are captured in a robust manner following the editorial guidelines that are discussed in this paper. It is, therefore, worthwhile making electronic surveys as short as possible by asking the most pertinent questions for a given investigation (Groves, 2006). This can elevate the odds of yielding high response rates and large sample sizes (Albaum et al., 2010). One positive feature of some electronic survey companies is that completion times are estimated, meaning that adjustments can take place in this area. In other words, judgements can be made by marketing academics and graduate students about shortening their electronic surveys if they deem them to be overly lengthy.

Measurement factors

Profiling information

Although the core content of electronic surveys often surrounds testing conceptual models (Hulland et al., 2018; Sraha et al., 2020), it is also helpful to include a series of profiling questions that assess the characteristics of a given sample. For example, profiling questions may feature the number of employees, exporting practices, firm ages, respondents' industry experience, and beyond. This data contextualizes what type of people and/or organizations took part in an investigation, offering evidence that the survey captured the facets of an appropriate population (see Mahdi et al., 2024). In fact, capturing this data may allow certain issues to serve as control variables in a conceptual model (Aliakbari et al., 2025; Crick & Crick, 2024a).

Single-item versus multi-item scales

A common issue applying to electronic surveys is the use of single-item versus multi-item measures (Bergkvist & Eisend, 2021; Diamantopoulos et al., 2012). Single-indicators are most appropriately used when capturing the nomological properties of a latent variable that can be adequately measured through one question (Weisberg et al., 1996). For instance, when measuring export intensity, survey researchers could ask respondents for the percentage of businesses' annual sales that originate from their export markets (see Cadogan et al., 2009). However, multi-item scales allow trace evidence to be captured of more complex latent variables through several questions (as undertaken by Crick et al., 2023; Vorhies & Morgan, 2005). Similarly, open-ended questions are discouraged because they induce biases for key informants (Dillman et al., 2009). Such considerations should be noted when designing electronic surveys, so that the most suitable operationalizations are used. Here, established (i.e. tried-and-tested) scales are preferable, as there is a lower probability of problems with such operationalizations (Crick & Crick, 2023; Peter, 1981).

Variance is a big deal

When operationalizing constructs within electronic surveys, it is important to capture a sufficient degree of variance (Hinkin, 1998). To illustrate, an electronic survey could be used to measure the extent to which firms can maximize customer satisfaction (see Schirmer et al., 2018). Here, firms with varying levels of customer satisfaction must be sampled to explain what activities lead to poor, vis-à-vis, excellent outcomes. Should there be a lack of variance (e.g. only high-levels of a construct are captured), there will likely be weaker contributions to marketing theory and practice. Pre-testing (as covered later) should help to overcome this problem, such as exploring increasing the number of anchor points (Reynolds & Diamantopoulos, 1998). In short, electronic surveys may need to be adapted to capture sufficient degrees of variance for all constructs.

Robustness checks

Checking for face validity

Face validity denotes whether a particular quantitative method (e.g. via an electronic survey) measures what it is intended to operationalize (Bolton, 1993). In tandem with using established scales, this can be checked through an informant quality tool. This is a set of questions at the end of an electronic survey that asks respondents (via interval scales) about the extent to which they were qualified to participate in a study (see Crick & Crick, 2021; Katsikeas et al., 2006). In turn, marketing researchers can discard responses if such tools reveal that key informants do not perceive themselves as being knowledgeable enough to answer the survey questions. For instance, if a given respondent chooses to rate their answers as less than 3.00 (on a seven-point interval scale), this could be a benchmark to eliminate such poor-quality survey responses from their eventual datafile. That said, this might be a difficult decision to make if this results in a small sample size, but one that might be necessary to eliminate inaccurate information.

Addressing common method variance

Common method variance *'refers to the shared variance among measured variables that arises when they are assessed using a common factor'* (Siemsen et al., 2010, p. 456). Such biases can occur when electronic surveys are completed in a rushed manner, whereby, respondents show disregard for the questions – providing flawed information. Consequently, electronic surveys should be designed in a way that makes them as interactive (and short) as possible to increase the prospect of the key informants supplying accurate answers (Podsakoff et al., 2003). This encapsulates attention checks and not presenting questions in a certain order (e.g. based on the structure of a conceptual model), so that poor-quality survey responses can be removed (as undertaken by Crick & Crick, 2019).

To illustrate, an attention check is when a question is presented at a seemingly random point within an electronic survey – to evaluate the extent to which the key informants were paying attention to the content (Gummer et al., 2021). For instance, an electronic survey might be focused on service quality and organizational performance, but midway through, a certain question asks the respondents to provide a specific answer. Should a given respondent not choose the specified

option, this would suggest that they did not read the instructions, and therefore, their answers should be eliminated from the eventual datafile. Moreover, for emphasis, there must not be a clear structure within an electronic survey, for which the key informants should not be able to tell if a particular question(s) is to be used as an independent variable, outcome variable, moderator, or mediator (Crick, 2018). This way, respondents can provide answers that reflect their true views – without any pre-conceived biases about the causal mechanisms pertaining to the questions within an electronic survey.

That said, these procedural remedies do not guarantee that common method variance problems are solved. Thus, tests can be run, helping to ensure that a set of results are not biased by a common method factor (Hulland et al., 2018). One useful test is the marker variable technique. This involves designing an electronic survey to include a construct that is conceptually unrelated to most of the substantive latent variables (Lindell & Whitney, 2001). By including an adequate marker variable, and providing that the subsequent test shows common method variance is unlikely to be present, marketing researchers can elevate the robustness of their studies (Crick, 2024). The marker variable could be the earlier-mentioned informant quality tool, coupled with this construct being used to assess face validity (building upon Crick & Crick, 2021; Katsikeas et al., 2006).

Dealing with endogeneity bias

'Endogeneity concerns arise in situations where an explanatory or independent variable correlates with the error term (residual) of a specified model, rendering estimates inconsistent. This is because the coefficient estimate of the compromised explanatory variable contains the effect of unaccounted for variable(s) that also partially explain the dependent [outcome] variable' (Rutz & Watson, 2019, pp. 481–482). As an illustration, an electronic survey may be designed to capture data on the link between an export market orientation and export performance (Cadogan et al., 2009). When tested, the empirical findings might suggest that an export market orientation helps internationalized companies to boost their performance due to a positive and significant link between the independent variable and the outcome variable. Yet, the causal path between these two constructs could be biased (or spurious) by a missing variable (Sande & Ghosh, 2018. As such, endogeneity bias can be tested for to help to minimize such problems.

One way (albeit there are different viewpoints) is to undertake relevant tests using an instrumental variable (Zaefarian et al., 2017). An instrument is a construct that is conceptually directly related to an independent variable, but (in theory) is indirectly related to an outcome variable (Antonakis et al., 2010). Using the prior example of the export market orientation – export performance relationship (as per Cadogan et al., 2009), a suitable instrument could be an export-focused market-oriented corporate culture, as beliefs about the vitality of creating value for customers in export markets could facilitate behavioral forms of an export market orientation, leading to increased export performance (building upon Jean et al., 2016). Without articulating the mechanics of endogeneity bias tests in this paper, by researchers including a suitable instrumental variable(s) within electronic surveys, marketing academics and graduate students can make their studies more stringent.

Other conceptual and methodological issues

Pre-registration activities

Pre-registration is the process of planning and documenting the collection and analysis of empirical data (e.g. from electronic surveys) (Moore, 2016). This can be undertaken through planning the length of a given investigation, specifying the research questions, determining the purposes of the constructs (e.g. moderators versus mediators), estimating the ideal sample size, and considering the likely analysis techniques (Simmons et al., 2021). In doing so, pre-registration can assist marketing academics and graduate students to design robust electronic surveys, and when relevant, collect and analyze their data in a stringent manner. Nonetheless, it is appreciated that while there are some distinct features of pre-registration activities, these issues overlap with some of the other discussion points within this article.

Theory in electronic surveys

Theory serves as an underpinning lens to determine what constructs marketing researchers measure (and do not measure) within their investigations (Hunt, 1993). Thus, when designing electronic surveys, approaching such methods with a clear lens(es) is paramount for planning what constructs to (and not to) include. For instance, resource-based theory surrounds how companies orchestrate their resources and capabilities to outperform competitors (Barney, 2014). Hence, when infusing this lens into an electronic survey, one would typically operationalize marketing resources/capabilities, sales performance, a market orientation, and so on (Hamzah et al., 2023; Vorhies & Morgan, 2005). Here, the use of a clear theory assists marketing academics and graduate students to focus on latent variables that they seek to measure, rather than constructs that align with different theories. This is one way that an electronic survey can remain aligned with achieving a given research objective and not become distracted with peripheral issues (Weisberg et al., 1996).

Pre-testing and general testing

Pre-testing involves marketing researchers working with expert scholars and practitioners to ensure that their electronic surveys are robust, in terms of the questions being understandable, the language is clear, the most suitable measures are used, and beyond (Karami et al., 2023). There are two main forms of pre-testing, namely, de-briefing and protocol approaches. Although definitions vary, de-briefing is where such feedback is provided in real time, whereas, protocol involves comments being sent after pre-testing candidates have had an opportunity to review such surveys (Diamantopoulos et al., 1994). Both forms of pre-testing have notable benefits and drawbacks, so it may be helpful to use a combination of protocol and de-briefing to obtain as much feedback as possible before electronic surveys are administered (Crick & Crick, 2019; Reynolds & Diamantopoulos, 1998). Indeed, it is also recommended that marketing academics and graduate students should test their electronic surveys (via using a computer and smartphone) to help to ensure that the questions are understandable, any website links work, and so on.

Field interviews

Collecting preliminary insights (via field interviews) can be used to enhance the development of electronic surveys (Mahdi et al., 2024). This is not the same as mixed-methods research, as the qualitative data is introductory, in which it is utilized to shape a set of measurement scales and align an electronic survey with the relevant population of interest. As an example, Katsikeas et al. (2006) focused on the *standardization versus adaptation debate*, in terms of whether companies should (or should not) adapt their products and services towards their foreign markets. Before they collected their survey data, they conducted some field interviews to refine their operationalizations and determine suitable key informants. This approach can help marketing researchers to design robust electronic surveys, so that appropriate questions are tailored to given settings. Put simply, field interviews can elevate the stringency of a given investigation involving an electronic survey (as per Crick, 2021; Crick & Crick, 2024b).

Final considerations about not overlooking basic issues

Choosing suitable empirical contexts and respondents

It is important to select an empirical context that not only hosts the issues being investigated, but also, is accessible, meaning survey responses can be feasibly obtained (Hulland et al., 2018). For example, coopetition (cooperation among competitors) has been studied in wine-producing countries, as vineyards and wineries are well-known for collaborating with their rivals in formal and/or informal capacities (e.g. Crick, 2022; Crick, Crick, et al., 2024; Mahdi et al., 2025). Thus, marketing academics and graduate students should determine their population of interest (with appropriate key informants that can knowledgeably answer questions), so that they launch their electronic surveys in empirical contexts to shape the extant literature (Homburg et al., 2012). Otherwise, there is little value in administering an electronic survey in a population of interest that is not renowned for whatever issues are under investigation – and is likely to be completed by inexperienced and/or unqualified key informants.

The little things that count

Although self-evident, it is important to design electronic surveys with appropriate spelling, grammar, and punctuation, and not confusing between British and American English (Dillman et al., 2009). Artificial intelligence software may be used to ensure that such details are accurate, alongside approaches, like translation/back-translation, where relevant (Huang & Rust, 2021). Translation issues usually arise in cross-national research, whereby, an electronic survey might need to be presented in a different language (Chidlow et al., 2014). Back-translation is the process of tasking a linguistic expert to convert the text back into the original language to ensure that a word-for-word translation took place (Douglas & Craig, 2007). Otherwise, such errors are easily spotted by respondents, which can make survey researchers look unprofessional, as well as reducing response rates and sample sizes (Schaeffer & Dykema, 2011).

Adhering to ethical procedures

Ethical issues are becomingly increasing important (encapsulating electronic surveys), in terms of the steps that marketing researchers should take to ensure they do not harm themselves, their participants, or other stakeholders linked to a given investigation (Cluley & Green, 2024). From an ethical perspective, marketing investigations are typically not as risky, vis-à-vis, other disciplines, such as medicine, psychology, and sociology (Yallop & Mowatt, 2016). Nonetheless, there are issues to be aware of, like ensuring that participants' identities are kept private, not asking for sensitive information (e.g. key accounting data), offering participation incentives, and storing such data in a safe place (as per Mecredy et al., 2024). As such, respective institutional ethics policies should be adhered to.

Cost factors

Electronic surveys (in marketing research and beyond) are usually cheaper than postal alternatives. These lower expenses are attributed to there being no stamp costs or printing fees, alongside typically being quicker to launch (Dillman et al., 2009). Nevertheless, marketing academics and graduate students must be aware of lesser-known expenses that relate to electronic surveys. These costs encapsulate paying for licences (e.g. access to software) and/or data collection services via market research agencies – if applicable (Crick, Friske, et al., 2024; Paas & Morren, 2018). Consequently, in addition to designing electronic surveys in a robust manner, marketing researchers must be conscious of not exceeding their budgets.

Summary and future research directions

The objective of this editorial article was to outline actionable recommendations concerning how marketing researchers (and peers in other domains) can design robust electronic surveys. This objective was achieved through reviewing notable studies within the marketing field (and beyond) to denote the most effective ways that stringent electronic surveys can be designed (e.g. Albaum et al., 2010; Stocchi et al., 2024). To consolidate the discussion points, a checklist was developed to showcase the salient issues when designing robust electronic surveys – and to limit the odds of marketing researchers collecting and analyzing sub-standard survey data (Appendix 1). These recommendations should assist marketing academics and graduate students to become more familiar, and confident, with designing robust electronic surveys (building upon Crick, 2024; Dillman et al., 2009). It is hoped that such recommendations can be utilized to address key under-researched areas within the marketing domain (and in other subject areas) to advance, and revitalize, the use of electronic surveys in the years to come (extending Hulland et al., 2018).

Moving forward, debates may arise from this article (linking with its theoretical and methodological limitations – albeit these are decidedly minor points), since further research will continue to improve the development of electronic surveys throughout the marketing field. For instance, this paper did not unpack statistical issues, nor the creative ways behind the designing of electronic surveys (following Deutskens et al., 2004; Popovich, 2024; Zaefarian et al., 2017). These are issues that can be addressed in future

research that involves electronic surveys (inside or outside of the marketing field). Thus, the authors actively encourage future studies to undertake more methodological work that delves deeper into the intricate ways that robust electronic surveys can be designed, coupled with the collection and analysis of stringent empirical data. It would be especially interesting if these methodological principles can be applied, and in turn, accurate survey findings are produced that uncover fresh insights about novel issues within the wider marketing discipline.

Notes

1. Other types of surveys (e.g. postal tools) are peripheral to the themes of this article – albeit some issues are transferrable (Hulland et al., 2018). Additionally, collecting and analyzing survey data is outside of the themes of this paper, since emphasis was placed on designing robust electronic surveys.
2. A variety of companies can be used to design electronic surveys (e.g. Qualtrics, Google Forms, and Survey Monkey). These organizations have their respective benefits and drawbacks, not least of which cost factors (Paas & Morren, 2018). Thanks is offered to an anonymous referee for seeking more depth on this point.

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